Mulembe18 Community Website Proposal

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1. Summary

Mulembe18 is a community website for members who live in Mombasa, Kenya. It has two jobs: to keep an accurate, living register of community members, and to make it easy to plan and attend events together. The goal is simple: people who share a background and a city should know each other, hear about gatherings in time, and show up.

This document is the plan I will follow. It covers why the site is needed, what it will do, how it will be run, how it will be built, and the order in which things will happen. Items marked in [square brackets] are decisions or facts I still need to fill in.

2. Background and the problem

Community members living in Mombasa are spread across many estates, workplaces, colleges and churches. Today, finding each other and organising anything usually depends on WhatsApp groups, phone calls and word of mouth. That creates real problems:

- Nobody has a complete list of who lives in Mombasa, so people are missed.
- Announcements get buried in busy group chats.
- New arrivals (students, workers, families) have no obvious way to connect.
- Event organisers cannot tell how many people to expect, and the same few people end up doing all the work.
- Contact details are scattered in phones and old spreadsheets, and are lost when people change numbers.

Mulembe18 solves this by giving the community one trusted home online.

3. Vision, mission and values

Vision: a connected community in Mombasa where nobody who belongs is left out.

Mission: register community members living in Mombasa, bring them together, and make community events easy to plan and join.

Name: "Mulembe" is a greeting of peace, and the name signals welcome and unity. [Confirm the meaning of "18" and the exact community the name refers to, so the About page and wording are accurate.]

Values: welcome, trust, respect for privacy, and community ownership.

4. Objectives

By the end of the first 12 months, I want to have:

- A working website where members can register themselves and manage their own profile.
- A searchable member directory with privacy controls the member decides.
- An events system where any approved member can propose an event and others can RSVP.
- A first group of members registered [target number, for example 100] and at least [target number, for example 3] events planned through the site.
- A small leadership team that runs the community side of the platform.

These numbers are placeholders. Set targets you are comfortable being held to.

5. Who the site is for

- **Members:** anyone from the community living in Mombasa who wants to be known and reachable.
- **Newcomers:** students, new workers and families who have just arrived and want to find their people.
- **Organisers and leaders:** the people who plan gatherings, collect contributions and share news.
- **Administrators:** a small trusted team that approves members and keeps the platform in order.

6. What the website will do

6.1 Phase 1 features (the minimum to launch)

Home page. A clear welcome, what Mulembe18 is, a button to register, and the next upcoming events.

Member registration. A short form collecting only what is needed:

- Full name
- Phone number (and email if they have one)
- Area or estate in Mombasa
- Occupation or institution (optional)
- How they would like to be contacted
- Consent to be listed, with a choice of what is visible

Approval. New registrations are reviewed by an admin before they appear publicly, so the register stays trustworthy.

Member directory. Approved members can search by name or area. Contact details are only shown to logged-in members, and each person controls what others can see.

Events. A page listing upcoming and past events with date, time, venue, description and an RSVP button. Organisers can create and edit events. Admins can approve them.

Announcements. A simple notice board for community news, such as bereavements, celebrations, meetings and opportunities.

Admin dashboard. Approve members, manage events and announcements, and export the register.

6.2 Phase 2 features (after launch, once people are using it)

- SMS and email notifications for new events and reminders.
- Event check-in on the day, so attendance is recorded.
- Optional contributions for events and welfare, paid by M-Pesa.
- Interest groups, for example youth, professionals, students, women, and men.
- A photo gallery from past events.
- A simple map or list view of members by area.

6.3 Later ideas

- A community business directory, so members can support each other's businesses.
- A jobs and opportunities board.
- A mentorship matching tool for students and young professionals.
- Swahili and English language options.

7. Membership, roles and governance

Roles

- **Visitor:** can see the home page, the About page and public events.
- **Member:** an approved person who can see the directory, RSVP to events and post to the notice board.
- **Organiser:** a member trusted to create events.
- **Admin:** approves members, edits content and sees the full register.

Who runs it. I suggest a small steering group of [3 to 5 people] chosen by the community, with a chairperson and a secretary. I build and maintain the platform; the steering group owns the community decisions, such as who may join and what events happen. [Decide who the first steering group will be.]

Joining rules. Membership is open to community members who live in Mombasa. [Decide whether a referral from an existing member is required, and how people are verified.]

Conduct. A short code of conduct will be shown at registration: be respectful, no hate speech, no political campaigning, no selling to members without permission. Admins can remove members who break it.

8. Privacy and data protection

The site will hold personal information, so this must be handled properly from the start.

- Follow the Kenya Data Protection Act, 2019. Check whether the project must register with the Office of the Data Protection Commissioner, and do it if so.
- Collect only what is needed, and say clearly why it is collected.
- Ask for consent at registration, and let members edit or delete their profile at any time.
- Never show phone numbers or emails to the public, only to logged-in members, and only if the member allows it.
- Store data securely, use HTTPS, protect admin accounts with strong passwords, and keep backups.
- Publish a short, plain-language Privacy Policy and Terms page.

9. How events will work

The event flow is meant to be simple enough that anyone can organise something.

1. An organiser proposes an event: title, date, time, venue, description, and expected cost if any.
2. An admin approves it and it appears on the Events page.
3. Members RSVP (going, maybe, not going). The organiser sees the live headcount.
4. Reminders are sent a few days before and on the day.
5. After the event, the organiser adds photos and a short report, and the event moves to Past Events.

10. Technical approach

I will build the site myself with tools I already work with, keeping it simple and cheap to run.

- **Front end:** a responsive web app (Next.js with Tailwind CSS), designed mobile first, because most members will visit on their phones.
- **Back end and database:** a managed database with built-in login (for example Supabase or Firebase), so I do not have to build authentication from scratch.
- **Hosting:** Vercel or similar, with the custom domain [mulembe18.co.ke or similar, to be confirmed].
- **Notifications:** Africa's Talking for SMS, and an email service for emails.
- **Payments (Phase 2):** M-Pesa through the Daraja API for event contributions.
- **Admin tools:** a protected admin area inside the same app.
- **Analytics:** a simple, privacy-friendly analytics tool to see visits and registrations.

The home page design is already drafted as a separate design file, and will guide the visual style: a deep green and amber palette that feels warm and welcoming.

11. Roadmap

Phase 0: Foundations (weeks 1 to 2)

- Confirm the name, the community it serves and the steering group.
- Secure the domain and set up hosting.
- Agree the registration form fields and the privacy approach.

Phase 1: Build the core (weeks 3 to 8)

- Build the home page, registration, login and the admin approval flow.

- Build the member directory with privacy controls.
- Build events with RSVP, and the announcements board.
- Write the Privacy Policy, Terms and code of conduct.
- Test with 10 to 15 friendly members and fix problems.

Phase 2: Soft launch (weeks 9 to 10)

- Invite a first group of members and gather their feedback.
- Hold one small event planned entirely through the site.
- Fix what did not work.

Phase 3: Public launch (weeks 11 to 12)

- Announce to the whole community through WhatsApp groups, churches, institutions and word of mouth.
- Publish the first announcements and a calendar of events.

Phase 4: Grow and improve (month 4 onward)

- Add SMS reminders, check-in and M-Pesa contributions.
- Add interest groups and the gallery.
- Review the numbers every month and decide what to build next.

12. Launch and growth plan

- **Start with trusted people.** Ask a few respected members to register first and invite others.
- **Go where people already are.** Share the registration link in existing WhatsApp groups, and put a QR code on posters and at events.
- **Make the first event count.** A well-organised first gathering, planned through the site, is the best advertisement.
- **Make registering easy.** The form should take under two minutes on a phone.
- **Keep it alive.** Post something useful every week: an event, a notice or a welcome to new members.
- **Ask for feedback often,** and show members what changed because of it.

13. Risks and how to handle them

- **Few people register.** Use trusted leaders to invite others, hold an in-person launch and keep the form short.
- **Privacy concerns.** Explain clearly how data is used, make visibility optional and never expose contacts publicly.
- **Fake or unwelcome sign-ups.** Admin approval and, if needed, member referrals.
- **The site goes quiet.** Share the load across a steering group, and schedule regular content and events.
- **Running costs.** Keep the stack simple and low cost, and use voluntary contributions if costs grow.
- **Too much depends on one person.** Document how the site works and train a second admin.

14. Budget and sustainability

The site can start very cheaply. The figures below are placeholders to fill in once quotes are confirmed.

- Domain name (yearly): [KES amount]
- Hosting and database (monthly): [KES amount, may be free at first]
- SMS credit (Phase 2, per month): [KES amount]
- Email service: [KES amount or free tier]
- Printing for posters and launch: [KES amount]
- Launch event: [KES amount]

How costs are covered: [options to decide: voluntary member contributions, a small annual membership fee, event contributions, or a sponsor from a community business]. Whatever is chosen, it should be reported openly to members.

15. How we will measure success

- Number of registered and approved members.
- Share of members who log in at least once a month.
- Number of events planned through the site, and average attendance.
- Number of new members who joined after finding the site.
- Feedback from members, collected twice a year.

16. Decisions I need to make next

1. Confirm what "Mulembe18" stands for and who the community is.
2. Choose the steering group and the first admin.
3. Decide the joining rules: open, or referral only.
4. Choose the domain name and register it.
5. Decide how running costs will be covered.
6. Set the first-year targets for members and events.
7. Pick a date for the soft launch event.

17. Conclusion

Mulembe18 is a small, focused idea with a clear purpose: to know who we are in Mombasa and to gather more often. By starting with registration, a trusted directory and easy event planning, and growing only as the community uses it, the project stays simple, affordable and useful. The next step is to settle the open decisions in section 16 and begin Phase 0.